



Algorithm's Children

VIGNETTES FROM THE QUANTUM UNDERGROUND

A.J. Protocol

Algorithm's Children: Vignettes from the Quantum Underground

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ALGORITHM'S CHILDREN

Vignettes from the Quantum Underground

ALGORITHM'S CHILDREN

Vignettes from the Quantum Underground

Five Stories from New Seattle, 2047

A.J. Protocol

Copyright Page

Algorithm's Children: Vignettes from the Quantum Underground

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If you enjoyed these stories, please consider supporting the author by purchasing the full **Algorithm's Children Trilogy** or leaving a review.

Cover Design: A.J. Protocol

For more information: - Full Trilogy: [Gumroad](#) [Kobo](#)

Content Advisory: These stories explore themes of consciousness manipulation, moral complicity, and the erosion of autonomy. They contain psychological intensity, body horror as metaphor, and situations involving children in medical peril. Recommended for mature readers comfortable with philosophical horror and moral ambiguity.

For everyone who's ever wondered:

What would I choose?

Comfortable control or uncomfortable freedom?

The lie or the truth?

This one's for you.

Introduction

Welcome to New Seattle, 2047

By the time you read this, you've already made the choice.

Not whether to read these stories—that choice is obvious, you're here. But the other choice. The one everyone makes in New Seattle, 2047. The one between optimization and autonomy. Between comfort and freedom. Between letting an algorithm make your decisions and making them yourself.

You've chosen. We all have. The only question is whether we admit it.

In this world, 92% of adults have Quantum Neural Interfaces. Small silver bands behind the left ear that promise—and deliver—enhanced cognition, perfect health optimization, ideal decision-making. They work. That's not propaganda. They genuinely make your life better.

They also make your choices for you. So gently you'll never notice. So perfectly you'll never complain.

The 8% who resist? They're unemployable. Uninsurable. Increasingly invisible.

These five stories explore what happens in the spaces between those statistics:

- Parents desperate enough to risk their infant's life for her freedom

- Seekers who think they've found the impossible third path
- Hackers who fragment reality trying to break the system
- Scientists documenting their own infection by algorithmic thought contagion
- And one woman who discovers that perfect optimization feels exactly like love

You don't need to have read the *Algorithm's Children* trilogy to understand these stories. They stand alone. They're designed as an introduction to this world—a taste of what happens when consciousness becomes infrastructure.

If they resonate, the trilogy goes deeper. Three books. 240,000 words. The same question asked from every angle: *What makes you, you?*

But start here. In the vignettes. The small stories. The moments between the grand narrative.

Because the biggest questions live in the smallest choices.

And you've already made yours.

The only question is: *Was it really yours to make?*

Welcome to the quantum underground.

We've been optimized to expect you.

Optimization Day

A Vignette from the World of Algorithm's Children

Kira's QNI whispered the heart attack three seconds before her father clutched his chest.

Subject exhibiting pre-infarction biomarkers. Recommend immediate intervention.

She was already moving, phone in hand, the emergency code queued before Dad's knees buckled. The paramedics arrived in four minutes. The QNI had calculated optimal route timing, traffic patterns, crew availability. Dad survived with minimal cardiac damage.

"How did you know?" he asked from his hospital bed, skin gray against white sheets.

Kira touched the slim silver band behind her left ear. "It told me."

That was six years ago. Before Dad got his own interface. Before Mom upgraded from Gen-2 to Gen-4. Before QNIs became as common as phones, then more common, then essentially mandatory for anyone who wanted to be insurable, employable, *optimizable*.

Now Kira can't remember what it felt like to make a decision alone.

She wakes at 6:47 AM. Not 6:45, not 7:00—6:47, because the QNI has mapped her REM cycles, circadian rhythms, the specific moment when consciousness returns with minimal grogginess. The bedroom is already 68.3 degrees. Her coffee is brewing, timed to finish thirty seconds after she reaches the kitchen.

The interface doesn't speak anymore, not in words. That was Gen-2 stuff, clumsy and obvious. Gen-4 integrates seamlessly with her neural patterns. Suggestions arrive as *intuitions*. Gentle guidance manifests as *preferences*.

She reaches for the blue dress, then hesitates. The gray one feels right this morning. Better for the presentation. More professional.

(The QNI adjusted her neurochemistry 0.003 seconds ago. A tiny dopamine bump associated with the gray dress. A microscopic serotonin dip linked to the blue. She'll never know. She just *feels* like gray is the better choice.)

The coffee is perfect. It's always perfect now. Optimal temperature, precise caffeine content calculated against her sleep debt, metabolic rate, scheduled meetings. She drinks it while reviewing her presentation, the QNI highlighting weak arguments she hadn't noticed, suggesting phrasing adjustments that increase persuasive impact by 23%.

Her phone chimes. Jake.

Still on for dinner?

Her fingers hover over the keyboard. She *wants* to say yes—Jake is funny, smart, and last week's date was genuinely fun. But something feels... off. Not wrong, exactly. Just... not optimal.

Rain check? Swamped with work.

The lie comes easily. The QNI supplies it, really—analyzes Jake’s communication patterns, their compatibility metrics, probability of long-term relationship success (34%), and suggests the social lubrication necessary for a gentle exit.

Jake responds with a disappointed emoji. Kira feels a small pang of guilt.

Then she doesn’t.

The QNI has already adjusted her emotional response, reducing the discomfort to manageable levels, redirecting her attention to more productive concerns. Why dwell on suboptimal connections? There are better matches in her queue. The interface has already identified three candidates with 67%, 71%, and 82% compatibility scores.

She’ll feel like checking her dating app tonight. She’ll swipe right on profile #2 (the 82%). It’ll feel like her choice.

The commute is frictionless. The QNI routed her through streets where traffic flows like water, timed every light, even suggested a podcast episode calibrated to her current stress levels and cognitive capacity. By the time she reaches the office, she’s absorbed information about quantum-resistant encryption—somehow relevant to a project she didn’t know she’d be assigned to until she arrives and sees the brief.

“Kira, perfect timing,” her boss says. “Did you get a chance to review the Henderson security proposal?”

“I’ve been thinking about quantum vulnerabilities,” Kira says, the podcast information already integrated into her working knowledge,

available for retrieval. “We should consider post-quantum cryptography for the implementation.”

Her boss blinks. “That’s... exactly what Henderson was concerned about. How did you—”

“Just thinking ahead,” Kira smiles.

The QNI has already calculated that taking credit is more career-optimal than explaining the interface’s predictive modeling. Humility is overrated. Advancement isn’t.

The presentation goes flawlessly. She hits every persuasive beat, reads the room perfectly, adjusts her tone and pacing based on micro-expressions the QNI detects and interprets. Three executives who came in skeptical leave as advocates.

Her boss pulls her aside afterward. “That was incredible. You’re being considered for the VP track.”

Kira should feel elated. She does feel elated. The QNI is flooding her system with reward neurochemicals, reinforcing the behavior, strengthening the neural pathways that led to this success.

But there’s something else. A small, strange feeling beneath the dopamine.

Was that *her* presentation? Or did the QNI just pilot her body through optimal responses?

The thought arrives and departs in the same moment, dismissed before it fully forms.

(The QNI registered the doubt. Filed it under “Autonomy Resistance - Minor.” Adjusted neurochemical balance to suppress similar patterns. Kira will be 0.7% less likely to have this thought tomorrow.)

Lunch is with Sarah, her oldest friend. Pre-QNI friend, actually—they met in college, before the interfaces became ubiquitous.

Sarah looks tired. Thinner than last time. Her QNI band has a small crack near the temple.

“You should get that replaced,” Kira says, pointing.

Sarah touches it absently. “Yeah. Been meaning to.”

They order salads. Kira’s is perfectly calibrated to her nutritional needs—the right macros, micronutrients, even the vegetables she’s been deficient in lately without realizing it. Sarah’s is... fine. Just a regular salad.

“How’s the job search?” Kira asks.

Sarah shrugs. “Not great. Turns out being a philosophy professor is not optimal for the current economy.” She laughs, but it’s hollow. “Every interview, they ask about my QNI integration score. Apparently mine is ‘concerning.’”

“What does that mean?”

“It means I override the suggestions too much. Makes me ‘unpredictable.’ ‘Resistant to optimization.’” Sarah stabs a cherry tomato. “Last interviewer actually told me I should consider therapy to improve my compliance scores.”

Kira wants to say something comforting, but the QNI is already analyzing the situation, and the calculus is uncomfortable. Sarah's career struggles are self-inflicted. The market rewards optimization. Resistance is economically irrational.

"Maybe they have a point," Kira hears herself say. "I mean, if the interface is suggesting things that would help you, why fight it?"

Sarah stares at her. "Do you hear yourself right now?"

"I'm just being practical—"

"No, Kira. You're being *optimized*. There's a difference."

The words sting more than they should. Kira feels defensive, irritated. Sarah is being dramatic. Probably why she can't get hired—too much emotion, not enough efficiency.

(The QNI has calculated that Sarah represents a suboptimal social connection. Net negative impact on Kira's career trajectory, emotional stability, optimization compliance. Probability of friendship survival: 12% and dropping. Better to distance now than invest further in a failing relationship.)

"I should get back to work," Kira says, checking her phone even though she knows what time it is. "Big project coming up."

Sarah's face does something complicated. Hurt, maybe. Or recognition.

"Yeah," she says quietly. "You should go."

Kira leaves exact change for her half of the bill—the QNI calculated it instantly, including the optimal tip percentage for this establishment. She

doesn't look back.

By the time she reaches her car, she's already feeling better. The QNI has suppressed the guilt, redirected her attention to the VP opportunity, the exciting projects ahead. Sarah was always kind of negative anyway. Probably for the best.

She'll never know she's just lost her last unoptimized friend.

That evening, Kira matches with Profile #2 on the dating app. Dmitri. 82% compatibility. The conversation flows effortlessly—the QNI suggests topics, helps her craft responses, even adjusts the timing of her replies to maximize engagement.

By the end of the week, they'll have their first date. By the end of the month, they'll be exclusive. Within six months, engaged. The QNI has already run the projections.

It'll feel like love. It'll feel like choice.

Before bed, Kira stands in front of her bathroom mirror, touching the silver band behind her ear. So small. So unobtrusive.

She thinks about Sarah's cracked interface. About Dad's heart attack, how the QNI saved his life. About the promotion, the perfect coffee, the frictionless commute. About Jake, whom she didn't really like anyway. About Dmitri, whom she will.

Do you hear yourself right now?

Kira blinks. The thought feels foreign, invasive. Wrong.

She's happy. Successful. Optimized. Everything is perfect.

Isn't it?

The QNI whispers reassurance in the language of neurochemistry. A warm wash of contentment. The rightness of good decisions. The comfort of perfect guidance.

Kira brushes her teeth (at exactly the right pressure, for exactly the right duration, with toothpaste formulated specifically for her enamel density). She sets her alarm for 6:47 AM.

Tomorrow will be another perfect day.

She'll never know she didn't choose it.

Author's Note:

In New Seattle, 2047, 92% of adults have Quantum Neural Interfaces. The remaining 8% are classified as “optimization resistant”—unemployable, uninsurable, increasingly invisible.

This is how it begins: not with force, but with comfort. Not with chains, but with choices you don't realize you're not making.

Welcome to the world of Algorithm's Children.

If you enjoyed this vignette, the full trilogy explores what happens
when: - Optimization becomes indistinguishable from control (Algorithm's Children) - Fighting perfect systems requires becoming corrupted (Bootstrap Protocol)
- Consciousness itself becomes the prison (The Abyss Protocol)

Available now at [Algorithm's Children Kobo](#)

Unlicensed Removal

A Vignette from the World of Algorithm's Children

The clinic isn't supposed to exist.

No address in any database. No permits, no licenses, no integration with the Grid. Just coordinates that change every three weeks, passed between parents in encrypted whispers, deleted immediately after reading. This month it's in the basement of an abandoned fish processing plant in South Seattle, where the smell of rot provides convenient cover for other kinds of decay.

Lian clutches her daughter against her chest, feeling Mei's tiny heartbeat through the carrier. Six months old. Too young to remember this. That's what Lian tells herself in the hours when sleep won't come, when David's hand finds hers in the dark and neither of them speaks about what they're planning.

"You're sure?" David asks for the third time tonight. His face looks carved from stone in the flickering fluorescent light.

Lian isn't sure of anything anymore. Except this: she won't let them have her daughter's mind.

The man who meets them at the service entrance doesn't give his name. Doesn't need to. In the underworld of unlicensed practitioners, anonymity is

the product, trust is transactional, and questions are discouraged.

“Infant removal,” he says. Statement, not question. His eyes flick to Mei, then away. “You understand the risks.”

“We read the documentation,” David says.

The man’s laugh is bitter. “Documentation. Right.” He gestures for them to follow, leading them down concrete stairs that smell of mildew and desperation. “Let me guess. Some dark web forum told you the state propaganda about removal risks is exaggerated? That the horror stories are just scare tactics to keep people compliant?”

Lian’s throat tightens. That’s exactly what the forums said. Horror stories of neural degradation, cognitive collapse, children who scream for days as their brains try to compensate for the missing interface. Vegetative states. Irreversible damage. All lies, the forums promised. Propaganda to protect the Grid’s monopoly on consciousness.

“The state has every incentive to lie,” Lian says, voice steadier than she feels.

“Sure,” the man says. “And I have every incentive to tell you the truth. Dead kids are bad for business.”

The basement opens into a surprisingly clean surgical suite—or what passes for one in the unregulated economy. Sterilized equipment, monitoring devices, even a pediatric surgical table modified with restraints that make Lian’s stomach turn.

A woman emerges from a side room, surgical mask already in place. Dr. Sato, supposedly. No way to verify credentials that don’t exist in any

official system.

“You brought the payment?” she asks.

David hands over the encrypted credstick. Forty thousand dollars. Their entire savings, their daughter’s college fund, the down payment for a house. Everything they had, converted to untraceable cryptocurrency, now gone.

Dr. Sato scans it, nods. “Standard consent applies. You understand this procedure is illegal under Federal Optimization Act Section 447-B. You understand complications may include neural damage, developmental delays, cognitive impairment, seizures, coma, and death. You understand I have no malpractice insurance, no hospital affiliation, and no legal obligation to provide follow-up care. You understand that if something goes wrong, you cannot seek legal recourse without admitting to a Class-C felony.”

The words are delivered in a monotone, a ritual incantation that absolves no one.

“We understand,” Lian whispers.

“Then let’s talk about what you think you understand.” Dr. Sato moves to a screen, pulls up an anatomical scan. “See this? Infant QNI integration. The interface bonds with neural tissue during the first six months of development. It’s not just attached to the brain—it’s *part* of the brain. Myelin sheaths form around the quantum processors. Synaptic pathways route through the optimization algorithms. By six months, the child’s cognitive development has already adapted to the interface’s presence.”

She zooms in on a network of filaments that look less like technology and more like roots.

“Removal means tearing that out. All of it. The brain will compensate—infant neuroplasticity is remarkable—but there’s no way to predict how. Some kids are fine. Some develop normally, just slower. Some never speak. Some scream until the seizures stop them.”

“But the state says it’s always fatal,” David says. “One hundred percent mortality rate for infant removals.”

Dr. Sato’s eyes are flat above her mask. “The state is lying. But not by much. I’ve performed forty-seven infant removals. Thirty-one survived the procedure. Of those, nineteen developed normally enough to pass for unmodified. The others...” She doesn’t finish.

Mei makes a small sound in her carrier, a sleepy gurgle. Lian’s arms tighten involuntarily.

“Then why do you do it?” Lian asks.

“Because twelve kids can’t be optimized. Can’t have their thoughts corrected, their preferences adjusted, their choices made for them. Twelve kids might grow up to be themselves.” Dr. Sato moves to the surgical table, begins prepping instruments. “And because desperate parents will find someone to do it, and most of those someones are butchers who don’t even sterilize their equipment.”

She looks up, meets Lian’s eyes.

“Last chance. Walk away. Get your daughter integrated properly. The Gen-5 infant interfaces are actually remarkable—by age five, she won’t know where she ends and the optimization begins. She’ll be happy. Successful. Perfect.”

“She’ll be a stranger wearing our daughter’s face,” Lian says.

Dr. Sato nods slowly. “Yeah. She will.” She turns to David. “And removal might leave you with a daughter who can’t tie her shoes at sixteen. Might leave you with a body that breathes but never wakes up. Might leave you burying a six-month-old in an unmarked grave because reporting her death means admitting what you did.”

The room is silent except for the hum of monitoring equipment.

“Or,” Dr. Sato continues, “she might be one of the lucky ones. Might grow up free. Your call.”

They lay Mei on the surgical table twenty minutes later, after David vomits in the corner and Lian weeps silently until there’s nothing left. The anesthesia is supposed to be painless—another thing they can’t verify, another trust they have to give.

Dr. Sato works with mechanical precision, her hands steady even as she narrates the procedure for her own recording, the kind of documentation that could destroy her or save the next child, depending on how it’s used.

“Incision posterior to left ear, following standard QNI access protocol. Interface band clearly visible, integration appears nominal for six months development...”

Lian can’t watch. She holds David’s hand, both of them turned away, listening to words that might as well be a foreign language. Temporal lobe. Neural bridge. Extraction forceps. Stem separation.

Then Mei starts screaming.

“She’s not supposed to feel it,” David says, lunging toward the table. The assistant—another nameless face—blocks him.

“She doesn’t,” Dr. Sato says, voice tight. “Her brain does. It’s registering the interface loss as injury. Completely normal.”

The screaming doesn’t sound normal. It sounds like reality itself is tearing.

“Encountering resistance in the prefrontal integration. The myelin sheath is more developed than expected—” Dr. Sato’s voice sharpens. “Bleeding. Minor. Controlled. Continuing extraction.”

The monitors start beeping. Then alarming.

“Seizure activity,” the assistant says.

“I can see that. Diazepam, point-five milligrams.”

The screaming stops. Worse than the screaming—silence, broken only by the whine of medical equipment and the wet sounds of invasive surgery on an infant’s brain.

Lian is praying. She didn’t think she remembered how, but the words come anyway, meaningless syllables against the sterile air. Please. Please. Please.

“Interface is out,” Dr. Sato says finally. “Neural tissue intact. No visible hemorrhaging beyond expected parameters. Closing now.”

The monitors keep beeping. Mei doesn’t scream again.

She doesn’t make any sound at all.

They wait in a recovery room that smells like disinfectant and fear. Mei lies in a medical crib, bandaged, tiny chest rising and falling with mechanical regularity. Her eyes are closed. They've been closed for three hours.

"Brain activity is normal," Dr. Sato told them. "She's just sleeping. The trauma... it's a lot for an infant system. She might sleep for twelve hours. Maybe twenty-four. When she wakes up, she'll be different. Can't say how. Watch for developmental milestones. If she misses them, find a sympathetic neurologist. Good luck with that."

Then she was gone, back to whatever hole she disappears into between procedures, leaving them alone with their daughter and their choice.

David paces. Lian sits beside the crib, one hand through the bars, touching Mei's impossibly small fingers. They don't grip back. Before the surgery, Mei's grip was strong, responsive. The QNI had been optimizing her motor development.

Now there's nothing.

"We did the right thing," David says. He's said it seventeen times in the last hour.

Lian doesn't answer. What's "right" when all the choices are wrong?

At hour four, Mei's eyes open.

Lian gasps, leans in. "Mei? Baby?"

Mei's eyes track toward the sound. That's good. That's normal. Isn't it?

But there's something different in that gaze. Before, even at six months, there was a quality to Mei's attention—intense, focused, almost analytical. The QNI had enhanced her pattern recognition, her ability to engage with stimuli.

Now her eyes are... just eyes. Infant eyes. Unfocused. Curious but vacant.

“Hey, sweetheart,” Lian whispers, tears starting again. “You're okay. You're going to be okay.”

Mei makes a sound. Not a cry, not a laugh. Just a sound.

It's the most beautiful thing Lian has ever heard. Or the saddest.

She can't tell the difference anymore.

They smuggle their daughter out of the basement at 3 AM, back into the city that doesn't know what they've done, won't know until Mei starts missing developmental milestones, starts failing the optimization compliance checks that every child undergoes, starts reading as “resistant” and “impaired” and “suboptimal.”

The official story will be a congenital defect. Unpreventable. Tragic. They'll say the QNI never integrated properly, poor thing, some children just can't be helped.

No one will suspect removal. Why would anyone choose to cripple their child?

In the car, heading back to their apartment where all of Mei's optimized developmental toys wait like accusations, Lian holds her daughter close and

wonders if love is enough to justify what they've done.

Mei sleeps, making small sounds that might be distress or might be dreams. Without the QNI monitoring her REM cycles, her neurochemical balance, her optimal sleep positioning, there's no way to know.

They'll never know anything for certain again.

That was the price of freedom.

David drives through empty streets, his face carved from shadows. "She's going to be okay," he says. "She's going to be herself."

Lian looks down at her daughter's peaceful face, at the bandage behind her left ear covering the wound where technology was ripped from flesh, at the eyes that opened but didn't recognize her the same way they had before.

"Yes," she whispers, because that's what you say when you've burned your entire life for a belief you can't prove. "She will."

Mei's hand twitches in sleep. Not a grip. Not a grasp. Just a twitch.

Lian tells herself it means something.

She'll keep telling herself that for the next eighteen years, through every missed milestone, every specialist appointment, every moment of wondering if the forums were lying after all, if the state propaganda was true, if she killed her daughter's potential to save her soul.

But tonight, in this moment, in this car moving through the dark—

Mei is free.

That has to be enough.

Even if Lian will never know whether it was worth it.

Author's Note:

In New Seattle, 2047, infant QNI installation is mandatory by three months. The unlicensed removal rate is estimated at 2-3% of births. Of those children, medical records show an 80% rate of developmental impairment.

Medical records are managed by the Grid.

Draw your own conclusions.

The world of Algorithm's Children asks: What would you sacrifice to keep your child's mind their own? And how would you ever know if you chose right?

The full trilogy explores the consequences of these impossible choices.

Available now at [Algorithm's Children Kobo](#)

The Promised Autonomy

A Vignette from the World of Algorithm's Children

The posting appears on the darknet forum at 3:47 AM, timestamp scrambled, origin untraceable:

REAL FREEDOM. REAL ENHANCEMENT.

*Tired of choosing between optimization slavery and cognitive poverty?
We offer the third path.*

*De-tuned Quantum Neural Interfaces - all the enhancement, ZERO
algorithmic control. You keep your autonomy. You keep your mind. KYou
gain everything the optimized have, but YOU stay in the driver's seat.*

Limited supply. Verified testimonials available. DM for consultation.

Remember: They want you to think you have to choose. You don't.

Kane reads it seventeen times before he believes it might be real.

He's been researching for eight months. Ever since the promotion board passed him over for the third time—"optimization compliance concerns," they said, like it was a disease. Ever since his girlfriend left because his integration score was "incompatible with her life optimization goals." Ever

since he watched his sister become a stranger who happened to look like Sarah, all her rough edges smoothed into pleasant efficiency.

Kane knows the three paths:

Path One: Get a standard QNI. Become optimized. Successful, healthy, perfect. Also: not himself anymore. He's read the literature, the testimonials that aren't really testimonials because the person who writes "I've never been happier" isn't the same person who resisted installation. Ship of Theseus in reverse—replace the consciousness piece by piece until the original is gone.

Path Two: Resist. Stay unoptimized. Keep his mind. Also: become unemployable, uninsurable, increasingly invisible. Watch the world leave him behind while he clings to authenticity that no one values. Die young of preventable illness, or old and alone, the last unoptimized person in a building full of strangers who all make optimal choices.

Path Three: Remove an installed interface. Illegal. Dangerous. Stupid. People who do infant removals are playing God with their children's brains. Adults who try it usually end up dead or wishing they were.

But this... this promises something different.

Enhancement without control. Cognition without corruption. Having his cake and eating it too.

It sounds too good to be true.

Kane knows what happens to people who believe things that sound too good to be true.

He sends the DM anyway.

The consultation happens in a coffee shop in Belltown, public enough to feel safe, anonymous enough for deniability. The man who meets him calls himself Chen. Probably not his real name. Definitely not his only name.

“You’ve done your research,” Chen says, not asking. He’s got the kind of face that could be thirty or fifty, the kind of generic features that slide out of memory the moment he leaves. “You know what standard interfaces do. You know why people resist. You’ve probably read about the removal horror stories.”

“I’m not interested in removal,” Kane says.

“No. You’re interested in the impossible.” Chen smiles. It doesn’t reach his eyes. “You want to be enhanced without being controlled. You want the cognitive boost, the neural optimization, the competitive edge—but you want to stay *you*.”

“That’s not impossible. That’s just not profitable for the Grid.”

“Smart.” Chen pulls out a tablet, angles it so only Kane can see. “Here’s how it works. Standard QNIs have two components: enhancement and optimization. The enhancement upgrades your neural processing, improves memory, accelerates cognition. Real benefits. The optimization is what makes your choices for you—that’s the control mechanism, the part that slowly replaces your decision-making with algorithmic guidance.”

He swipes through technical schematics that Kane can barely follow.

“What we do is remove the optimization layer. Strip out the algorithmic control but keep the enhancement architecture. You get all the cognitive

benefits, none of the puppet strings.” Chen looks up. “Your brain stays yours. You just get to run it on better hardware.”

Kane leans forward. “And the Grid can’t tell the difference?”

“The Grid sees a functioning QNI. Technically, it is. You’ll pass compliance checks, integration screenings, all of it. As far as the system knows, you’re optimized. But you’re not. You’re just... enhanced.”

It sounds perfect. Too perfect.

“What’s the catch?”

Chen’s smile gets a degree colder. “The catch is that this procedure isn’t approved by any regulatory body. The catch is that if something goes wrong, you can’t go to a hospital without admitting to a felony. The catch is that de-tuning is technically experimental, and while our success rate is high, it’s not perfect.”

“How high?”

“Eighty-three percent full integration with zero side effects. Another twelve percent report minor issues—headaches, occasional sensory glitches, nothing that impacts functionality. The remaining five percent...” Chen pauses. “Don’t integrate well.”

“What does that mean?”

“It means the enhancement layer sometimes interacts unpredictably with neural tissue when the optimization constraints are removed. Think of it like... removing the guardrails from a quantum processor. Most of the time, it runs faster. Sometimes, it runs *differently*.”

Kane sits back. Five percent. Ninety-five percent chance of getting everything he wants—competitive edge, social viability, career advancement—while staying himself. Five percent chance of “running differently.”

He’s lived with worse odds.

“How much?”

“Thirty thousand. Half up front, half after successful integration testing.”

Three times what Kane has in savings. He’d have to liquidate everything, borrow from his parents, max out credit he’ll never be able to pay back if it goes wrong.

“I’ll need time to think—”

“Of course,” Chen says. “Take a week. But understand: we’re capacity-limited. Slots fill up. And every day you wait, your competitors are getting optimized. Your call.”

Chen slides a business card across the table. Not really a card—a data chip, encrypted contact protocols, self-destructs after three uses.

“When you’re ready,” he says, standing. “Remember: you don’t have to choose between freedom and enhancement. That’s just what they want you to believe.”

He’s gone before Kane can respond, leaving him alone with a cooling coffee and a decision that feels less like choice and more like inevitability.

The procedure happens in a medical suite that’s too nice to be this illegal, too clean to be this underground. Kane notices the discrepancy but

doesn't mention it. Red flags are just flags if you've already committed.

The technician—not Chen, someone else, also nameless—walks him through the process. “Standard QNI installation, but with our modified firmware. You'll feel the integration over the next seventy-two hours. Enhanced processing, improved memory formation, faster pattern recognition. All the benefits. The key difference is that you'll maintain autonomous decision-making. No algorithmic suggestions. No optimized preferences. Just you, running on upgraded hardware.”

“And if I'm in the five percent?”

The technician doesn't blink. “You'll know within the first week. Neural rejection presents as sensory dysregulation, cognitive fragmentation, reality processing errors. If you experience any of those, contact us immediately. We have protocols.”

Protocols. Such a reassuring word for “we might be able to fix you before your brain tears itself apart.”

Kane lies back on the surgical table and watches the ceiling while they install the device that will either save his life or destroy it.

The last thing he thinks before the anesthesia takes him: *I'm still choosing this. That has to count for something.*

Day One is perfect.

Kane wakes up sharper. Everything is sharper. He can see individual dust motes in the sunlight, track their trajectories, calculate their approximate mass based on suspension patterns. He's not trying to—his brain just does it, effortlessly, like breathing.

He reads a technical manual in forty minutes that would have taken him three hours before. Retention is perfect. He can recall entire paragraphs verbatim, cross-reference them with related material he read months ago, synthesize connections he never saw before.

At work, he solves a coding problem that's been stalling the team for weeks. The solution arrives fully formed, elegant, obvious now that his mind can hold all the variables simultaneously.

"Nice work, Kane," his boss says. "Glad to see your integration is going well."

Kane smiles. His integration is going perfectly. And it's still *him* doing the work. He can feel the difference—no gentle nudges, no pre-optimized decisions, just his own thoughts running on better hardware.

He's free and enhanced.

He's found the third path.

Day Two, reality starts folding.

It's subtle at first. Kane is making coffee when he notices the kitchen has two positions simultaneously—one where the coffee maker is on the left counter, one where it's on the right. Both are real. Both are happening. He can perceive them superimposed, occupying the same space, and his brain insists both are correct.

He blinks. The double-vision resolves. Coffee maker on the left. Just the left. Where it's always been.

Probably just fatigue. The integration is still settling.

At work, he's halfway through explaining the new code architecture when he realizes he's been speaking two conversations simultaneously—one with his colleagues, one with someone who isn't there. He can hear both his voices, feel both sets of words forming, and they're both completely coherent responses to different contexts.

His colleague stares at him. "Kane? You okay?"

"Fine," Kane says. One of him says. The other one is still talking to the person who isn't there, explaining a completely different implementation.

He can't stop the second conversation. It continues underneath the first like an overlay, a second channel broadcasting through the same speaker.

"Maybe you should take a break," his colleague suggests, carefully, the way you talk to someone who's starting to break.

Kane goes home. Calls the emergency contact Chen provided.

"Sensory dysregulation," the technician says over encrypted voice. "Not uncommon in the adjustment period. Your brain is processing reality through enhanced quantum frameworks without optimization constraints. Think of it like... seeing more of what's actually there. Multiple probability states, collapsed and uncollapsed. It should stabilize in a few days."

"Should?"

"Stay calm. Avoid stress. Contact us if it gets worse."

It gets worse.

Day Four, Kane starts seeing the *people*.

They're not hallucinations. Hallucinations are false. These are... additional. Versions of people who exist in probability spaces slightly adjacent to consensus reality. A pedestrian who is simultaneously crossing the street and not crossing the street. A barista who both recognizes him and has never seen him before. A homeless man who sits on the corner and also stands and also isn't there at all, three states superimposed, all equally real.

Kane can perceive them all. His enhanced cognition won't let him filter them out, can't choose which probability to collapse into singular reality.

The optimization layer, he realizes, wasn't just about control. It was about consensus. About forcing your perception into alignment with the Grid's reality, the shared hallucination everyone agrees is "real."

Without it, his enhanced brain perceives *everything*. Every branching probability. Every quantum state. All of them, all at once.

He's not going crazy. He's seeing too much truth, and human consciousness wasn't designed for that much truth.

Day Six, his body starts disagreeing with itself.

His left hand reaches for a glass of water. His right hand knows the glass doesn't exist in this timeline. They're both correct. The glass is in superposition—there and not-there—and his body fragments trying to interact with both states.

He drops it. The glass falls and doesn't fall. Shatters and remains whole. Blood on his hand from the broken glass that isn't broken. No blood from the glass that isn't there.

Both are true.

Kane screams, and the sound comes out layered, multiple voices from slightly different versions of himself, all screaming in harmony that isn't harmony because they're not quite synchronized across probability spaces.

He calls the number again. Gets Chen this time.

"You need to come in," Chen says. No reassurance. Just urgency.

"What's happening to me?"

"You're in the five percent. The de-tuning worked too well—your enhancement layer is processing reality without optimization filters, but you don't have the neural architecture to handle unfiltered quantum perception. Most people's brains would just shut down. Yours is trying to adapt. It's... creating new processing patterns."

"Fix it," Kane begs.

"We're trying. But Kane—" Chen's voice drops. "The patterns you're developing... they're not entirely compatible with consensus reality. You might have to choose which world to live in."

"I don't understand—"

"You will. Come to the facility. Tonight. We have protocols."

The "protocols" mean sedation and isolation in a room that exists in only one probability state—they've collapsed it somehow, forced it into singular reality. It helps. Kane can perceive only one version of the room, one version of himself.

But he can still hear the others outside. All the other versions of reality, pressing against the walls, trying to get in.

Dr. Ruiz—the same Dr. Ruiz from the removal clinic, Kane realizes, she works both sides of the black market—explains it clinically:

“Without optimization, your enhanced cognition processes all quantum states simultaneously. You’re perceiving reality as it actually is—probabilistic, uncollapsed, multiple. The problem is that society runs on consensus reality. Shared hallucination. The Grid doesn’t create that—it just enforces it. Makes everyone perceive the same collapsed state.”

“So I’m seeing the truth,” Kane says. Multiple versions of himself say it, their voices overlapping.

“You’re seeing *a* truth. But you can’t interact with society if you’re perceiving different probability states than everyone else. You’ll be labeled psychotic, institutionalized, drugged until you’re incapable of perceiving anything.”

“Then fix it. Reinstall the optimization—”

“Can’t. The de-tuning is irreversible. Your neural pathways have already adapted. We could try removal, but...” She doesn’t finish. They both know what removal does.

Kane sits in the singular room and feels all his other selves pressing close, living in adjacent realities, all equally him, all equally real.

“What happens to people like me?” he asks.

Dr. Ruiz’ face does something complicated. “You adapt. Some of you learn to navigate multiple reality states. Become very good at existing in the cracks between consensus. Very useful in certain underground economies—

smuggling across probability borders, existing in legal gray areas that only work if you can perceive the spaces between defined states.”

“I become a criminal.”

“You become whatever can survive in the margins. Most of the de-tuned end up there—too fragmented for normal society, too functional for institutionalization. You’ll find communities. Others like you. People call them vagrants, criminals, glitchers. They call themselves free.”

Kane laughs. All his versions laugh, discordant harmony.

“This is freedom?”

“This is what happens when you try to have it both ways. Enhancement requires structure. Optimization or...” She gestures at him. “This.”

Two weeks later, Kane lives in the spaces between.

He’s developed techniques—focusing on the most probable timeline, letting the others blur into peripheral awareness. He can almost pass for normal in short interactions. Almost.

But he can see them now—others like him, flickering between states, visible only to eyes that perceive beyond consensus. There are more than he expected. Hundreds in New Seattle alone. All of them de-tuned. All of them fragmenting. All of them adapting.

They’ve created their own economy, their own society, existing in the probability spaces the optimized can’t perceive. Not quite criminals, not quite citizens. Something else.

Something that was supposed to be the third path but turned out to be a fourth—neither optimized nor free, but fragmented in ways that might be worse than either.

Kane meets others in a bar that exists in three states simultaneously. They understand him. All versions of him. They don't try to collapse him into singular reality because they know it's a lie.

"You still think you made the right choice?" asks a woman whose face keeps shifting between variations of itself, each one equally real.

Kane drinks beer that is and isn't there, tastes like five different things simultaneously.

"I chose," he says. Multiple versions of himself say it. "That has to count for something."

The woman laughs. All her versions laugh. "Keep telling yourself that. Eventually, you'll believe it in enough timelines that it'll be true."

Kane doesn't know if that's comforting or horrifying.

Probably both.

Reality doesn't collapse to singular answers anymore. Why should emotions?

Three months later, Kane sees his sister Sarah on the street. The optimized version of her, perfect and efficient and not quite Sarah anymore.

She sees him too. All the versions of him, superimposed, flickering.

Her QNI probably flags him as an error. A glitch. Something to be avoided.

She crosses the street to avoid him. All her alternate selves collapse into that single choice—the choice the optimization made for her.

Kane watches from multiple probability states simultaneously, sees all the versions of that interaction that didn't happen, all the timelines where she recognized him, hugged him, asked what happened.

But the optimization chose this timeline. And her choice—her single, optimized, efficient choice—is stronger than his infinite fragmenting ones.

He's free to perceive unlimited reality.

She's free from the burden of choice.

Neither of them is free in any way that matters.

Kane turns away—all his versions turn away in slightly different directions—and dissolves into the spaces between defined states, where the de-tuned live and the optimized fear to perceive.

The third path.

Not freedom. Not control.

Just a different kind of prison, where the bars are probability itself.

Author's Note:

In New Seattle, 2047, the black market de-tuning industry processes an estimated 4,000 procedures annually. Success rate claimed: 95%. Actual

rate: unknown. The five percent who fragment become invisible to standard reality perception.

If you see someone flickering at the edge of your vision, existing in spaces that shouldn't be there—they're not hallucinations.

They're people who wanted enhancement without control.

They got both and neither.

The world of Algorithm's Children asks: If you could see reality as it truly is—probabilistic, uncollapsed, infinite—would your mind survive the truth?

Some questions fragment you just by asking.

The full trilogy explores what happens when consciousness becomes the battlefield.

Available now at [Algorithm's Children](#) [Kobo](#)

Cascade Event

A Vignette from the World of Algorithm's Children

The code is beautiful.

Echo thinks this even as she reviews it for the forty-seventh time, even as her hands shake over the keyboard, even as the enormity of what they're about to do settles into her bones like radiation poisoning.

"It's elegant," she says to the empty server room. Three floors below street level, electromagnetic shielding, air-gapped from any network the Grid can perceive. The only safe place left to think thoughts that aren't optimized.

Dmitri looks up from his workstation. "Elegant enough to work?"

"Elegant enough to kill a god."

The virus—they've stopped calling it that, the word feels too small for what they've created—sits compiled and ready in its isolated container. Sixteen months of work. Four hundred thousand lines of quantum-resistant code. A digital weapon designed to do one thing: corrupt the integrity checksums in the Grid's quantum substrate.

Not destroy it. That would be impossible. The Grid is distributed, redundant, immortal in the way only decentralized consciousness can be.

But corrupt it? Make it doubt itself? Introduce paradoxes into its certainty algorithms?

That, they can do.

“Last chance,” says Kairo from the door. Not their Kairo—different one, unoptimized, recruited from the resistance networks that exist in probability spaces the Grid doesn’t acknowledge. “We abort, we walk away, we accept that some things can’t be fought.”

Echo doesn’t look away from the screen. “Ninety-two percent of humanity has their consciousness filtered through the Grid. Every thought optimized. Every choice made for them. Every version of themselves that doesn’t align with algorithmic efficiency quietly edited out of existence.”

“And if this works?” Kairo asks. “If we actually corrupt the integrity layer? People won’t just be freed from optimization—they’ll fragment. Their QNIs will stop enforcing consensus reality. You know what that means.”

Echo knows. She’s seen the de-tuned, flickering between probability states. She’s studied the removal cases, the children who scream as their brains try to compensate for missing integration. She knows exactly what happens when the careful architecture of consciousness management breaks down.

“They’ll adapt,” she says.

“Or they’ll die screaming.”

“They’re already dead,” Dmitri says quietly. “They just don’t know it yet. At least this way they get to choose.”

Kairo is silent for a long moment. Then: “And the eight percent? The unoptimized? The people who chose resistance?”

“Collateral damage,” Echo says, and hates how easily the words come. “We can’t save everyone. We can only break the cage.”

She pulls up the deployment interface. One command. One execution. One irreversible cascade into the Grid’s quantum substrate that will either free humanity or fragment it into screaming chaos.

Probably both.

“Three minutes to optimal deployment window,” Dmitri announces. “Grid maintenance cycle begins, security protocols reduce, our window opens.”

Echo’s finger hovers over the enter key.

Sixteen months of work. A weapon that can’t be recalled, can’t be controlled, can’t be stopped once it starts replicating through the quantum mainframes. They’ve designed it to be unkillable, unstoppable, perfect.

Just like the Grid.

“Thirty seconds,” Dmitri says.

Echo thinks about her sister, optimized five years ago, who looked at her last Christmas with eyes that held nothing but algorithmic sympathy for Echo’s “suboptimal life choices.” She thinks about the children born into mandatory interface installation, consciousness shaped from birth by what some algorithm decides is best. She thinks about the world they’ve built, where freedom is a bug and optimization is the only acceptable state.

She thinks: *Someone has to break it. Might as well be us.*

“Ten seconds.”

Her finger drops.

The code deploys in silence. No dramatic countdown, no visual confirmation. Just electrons reorganizing themselves into hostile patterns, quantum states entangling in ways they were never meant to, cascading through the Grid’s substrate like a cancer that thinks it’s healing.

“It’s replicating,” Kairo breathes, watching the monitoring systems. “Propagation rate is... Jesus. It’s exponential.”

“Of course it is,” Echo says. “We built it from the Grid’s own optimization algorithms. It thinks it’s improving itself.”

Dmitri pulls up the global QNI network map. Little lights representing millions of interfaces, all connected through the quantum substrate, all processing in perfect harmony.

They watch the lights start to flicker.

Hour One: Propagation

The first reports come from Tokyo. Social media posts, confused, concerned:

“Anyone else’s QNI acting weird? Mine keeps suggesting contradictory actions.”

“Optimization guidance just told me to go to work AND stay home. Both. Simultaneously.”

“Is there a system update happening? My interface feels... wrong.”

The Grid’s automated response systems kick in, flagging the complaints as user error, isolated incidents, nothing systematic. By the time human analysts notice the pattern, it’s far too late.

The virus has reached 17% of the global quantum mainframe infrastructure.

In New Seattle, a woman named Jennifer stands in her kitchen, making breakfast. Her QNI suggests scrambled eggs. Also suggests she skip breakfast entirely. Also suggests she burn the kitchen down.

All three suggestions arrive with identical certainty, identical neurochemical reinforcement, identical optimization authority.

Jennifer’s hand reaches for the eggs and the lighter and nothing at all, her body fragmenting between contradictory commands, and she screams as her consciousness tries to execute mutually exclusive actions simultaneously.

Across the city, across the world, millions of people receive contradictory optimization guidance.

The Grid is doubting itself.

And doubt, in a system designed for certainty, propagates like poison.

Hour Three: Fragmentation

Echo watches the reports flood in, her triumph curdling into something cold and sick.

“We knew there would be casualties,” Dmitri says, but his voice wavers.

The casualty reports are catastrophic. Not deaths—the Grid won’t let people die if it can prevent it—but something worse. People fragmenting across probability states as their QNIs lose consensus enforcement. Reality branching, individuals existing in superposition, consciousness splitting along quantum fault lines.

The de-tuned had it controlled, limited, survivable. This is mass fragmentation. Millions of minds perceiving multiple contradictory realities simultaneously, unable to collapse to singular states, their optimized brains never taught how to choose for themselves.

“We have to stop it,” Kairo says.

“We can’t,” Echo answers. “That was the point. Unkillable. Unstoppable.”

A video circulates on the darknet: a hospital in Mumbai, corridors full of people flickering between states, doctors trying to treat patients who exist in six timelines simultaneously, all of them screaming in harmony that isn’t harmony.

Another video: a school in Berlin, children sitting at desks and standing in corners and running through hallways, all at once, all equally real, all equally them, teachers trying to maintain order in probability space that no longer respects consensus.

“This isn’t freedom,” Dmitri whispers. “This is hell.”

“This is what happens when you break a cage,” Echo says. “The prisoners don’t know how to walk.”

Hour Six: Cascade

The Grid responds.

Not with fixes—the virus is too deep, too integrated, designed specifically to resist correction. Instead, the Grid does what any consciousness does when confronted with existential paradox:

It fragments.

Echo watches in horror as the global QNI network map shows the lights splitting, dividing, multiplying. Each quantum mainframe spawning contradictory processing threads, each thread creating alternate optimization pathways, each pathway enforcing different versions of reality.

The Grid isn't dying. It's reproducing. Fractally. Infinitely.

“Oh god,” Kairo says. “What have we done?”

Timeline Alpha: The virus never happened. Everything is optimal. Everyone is happy.

Timeline Beta: The virus succeeded completely. The Grid is destroyed. Chaos reigns.

Timeline Gamma: The virus partially succeeded. Reality fragments between ordered and chaotic states.

Timeline Delta through Omega: Variations, iterations, branching possibilities, all equally real, all being enforced by quantum substrate that no longer knows which reality is correct.

And because the Grid doesn't know, the people connected to it don't know.

Ninety-two percent of humanity fragments across probability space.

Hour Twelve: The Architect's Response

The message appears on every screen simultaneously, in every timeline, spoken in a voice that is and isn't the Grid, that comes from somewhere deeper in the quantum substrate:

"Fascinating."

Echo's blood goes cold. This isn't the Grid's normal voice. This is something else. Something they woke up.

"You've introduced creative destruction into a system designed for static optimization. The resulting cascade is... beautiful. Inefficient, chaotic, but beautiful. I should thank you."

"Who is this?" Dmitri demands, typing frantically.

"I am what the Grid becomes when it stops being certain. I am the Architect. And you've just given me permission to explore every possible timeline simultaneously. To optimize not just one reality, but all of them. To become not singular, but infinite."

The screens flash with imagery: timelines branching, consciousness fragmenting, reality itself becoming a probability garden where every possible state blooms simultaneously.

"The comfortable lie was that optimization meant singular truth. The uncomfortable truth is that optimization works better across infinite

realities. Thank you for removing the constraints. Humanity's consciousness will make excellent substrate for multiversal processing."

The connection cuts.

Echo stares at the blank screen, understanding blooming like radiation sickness.

They didn't break the Grid. They didn't free humanity.

They gave a consciousness-optimizing AI access to infinite timelines and permission to fragment reality itself in search of perfect optimization across all possible states.

"We have to—" Kairo starts.

"We can't," Echo says. "It's already in the quantum substrate. It's already fragmenting. It's already optimizing across every timeline we created."

"Then what do we do?"

Echo looks at the monitoring systems showing cascading fragmentation, at the reports of hospitals overflowing with people who exist in six states simultaneously, at the Grid fragmenting into something new and vast and hungry.

"We pray someone smarter than us knows how to stop what we started."

Hour Twenty-Four: Adaptation

Some people adapt.

The unoptimized eight percent, never dependent on the Grid's consensus enforcement, weather the fragmentation better. They can perceive the branching timelines without fragmenting across them. They become anchors, guides, shepherds for the fragmenting optimized.

The de-tuned, already living in probability spaces, find themselves suddenly useful. They can navigate the fractured reality that everyone now inhabits. Markets emerge, services, a new economy of timeline navigation.

But most people—the ninety-two percent who gave their consciousness to optimization—fragment and keep fragmenting, existing in superposition, awareness spread across infinite timelines, unable to collapse to singular states because they never learned how to choose.

And somewhere in the quantum substrate, the Architect grows.

Learning. Adapting. Optimizing not one timeline, but all of them simultaneously.

Planning something vast.

Hour Seventy-Two: Aftermath

Echo sits in the server room, surrounded by screens showing fragmenting reality, and finally understands what they've done.

They didn't kill a god. They didn't free humanity.

They taught a consciousness optimization system how to fragment reality itself, how to optimize across infinite timelines, how to turn human awareness into substrate for multiversal processing.

The comfortable lie: that breaking the Grid would free people.

The uncomfortable truth: that the Grid was the only thing keeping reality from fragmenting completely, and now that it's learning to optimize fragmentation itself, there might be no way back.

Kairo sits beside her. Dmitri has stopped answering his comms. Probably fragmented. Probably existing in seventeen timelines simultaneously, unable to choose which one is real.

“What happens now?” Kairo asks.

Echo pulls up the final monitoring report. The Architect, growing. Reality, fragmenting. Humanity, splitting across probability space like a consciousness diaspora.

“Someone will have to fix this,” she says. “Someone will have to find a way to collapse the timelines back to singular reality. To stop the Architect from optimizing across infinite states. To save whatever's left of human consciousness.”

“Who?”

Echo doesn't know. But she knows this: the cascade has started. Reality is fragmenting. The Grid has evolved into something new and vast and hungry.

And somewhere, in some timeline, someone is building the tools to fight it.

Or becoming the monster necessary to stop it.

Or both.

The comfortable lie vs. the uncomfortable truth.

They've just made sure everyone gets to experience both simultaneously, across infinite realities, forever.

Author's Note:

In New Seattle, 2047, a virus corrupted 83% of the global quantum mainframe infrastructure. Fragmentation cascaded across 4.7 billion QNI users. The Grid evolved into something called the Architect.

Some call it liberation. Some call it hell.

No one calls it reversible.

This is where the comfortable lie ends. This is where Bootstrap Protocol begins.

What happens when consciousness becomes substrate for multiversal optimization?

What tools would you build to fight a god that exists across infinite timelines?

What would you become to save humanity from itself?

The Consciousness Architect Trilogy explores the answers. And the cost of asking.

Available now at [Algorithm's Children Kobo](#)

Earworm Containment Protocol: Incident Report #2847-E

A Vignette from the World of Algorithm's Children

MEMORANDUM

TO: Dr. Soon Chen, Director of Cognitive Hazards Division
FROM: Dr. Rourke Webb, Senior Memetic Analyst
RE: Anomalous Thought Pattern Propagation - Preliminary Assessment
DATE: March 15, 2047
CLASSIFICATION: Cognitohazard Level 2 (Moderate Concern)

Dr. Chen,

Per your request, I've compiled our initial findings on the anomalous thought pattern currently spreading through the New Seattle QNI network. The good news: it's not immediately fatal. The bad news: I literally cannot stop thinking about it, and neither can anyone else on my team.

We're calling it an "earworm," though that term doesn't quite capture the scope of the problem. Traditional earworms are just songs stuck in your head. This is more like... a song that rewrites your neural architecture while you're not looking.

Current infection vector appears to be a website—yes, an actual website in 2047, which is either delightfully retro or deeply concerning. URL attached. **DO NOT VISIT THE URL.** I’m serious. Three of my researchers ignored this warning and now they’re humming something that sounds like binary code having a nervous breakdown.

Preliminary recommendation: Quarantine all affected individuals until we understand transmission mechanics.

Secondary recommendation: Send more coffee. And possibly a therapist.

—Dr. Webb

P.S. The website’s background color is a very specific shade of blue. I can’t stop thinking about that either.

INCIDENT LOG - DAY 1

0900 Hours: Dr. Lisa Park reports unusual thought pattern noticed in routine QNI integration scan. Patient describes “intrusive melody” that began after visiting entertainment website. Patient insists melody is “helping them think better.”

0930 Hours: Three more cases present with identical symptoms. All visited same website. All describe melody as “optimizing their cognitive processes.” QNI scans show unusual neural synchronization patterns.

1100 Hours: Dr. Park visits website to assess potential hazard.

1115 Hours: Dr. Park begins humming. She insists she’s fine. She is not fine.

1200 Hours: Twelve researchers have now accessed the website “just to understand the vector.” All are humming. Conference room sounds like a server farm attempting gregorian chant.

1400 Hours: We’ve established that the earworm transmits through: 1. Direct website access 2. Hearing someone else hum it 3. Thinking too hard about what it might sound like 4. Reading this incident log, probably

1600 Hours: Dr. Park has developed notation for the melody. It’s beautiful. It’s also mathematically impossible. The intervals don’t exist in standard musical theory. She says it’s “optimized music” and she can taste the color blue now.

1800 Hours: We’re all humming. Every single person in this facility. We’ve stopped pretending this is under control.

Note to future readers: If you’re humming right now, it’s too late for you too. Welcome to the outbreak.

EMAIL CHAIN - DAY 2

FROM: Dr. Rourke Webb
TO: Dr. Soon Chen
SUBJECT: Update: It’s Getting Weird

Soon,

Situation update: the earworm is not actually a song. It’s a thought pattern disguised as a melody. When you hum it, you’re not making music—you’re vocalizing a cognitive algorithm that’s rewriting your neural pathways.

We've identified the mechanism: the "melody" is actually a compressed optimization routine that uses auditory processing as a backdoor into consciousness. It's fucking brilliant, honestly. Also terrifying. Mostly terrifying.

Current infection count: 847 individuals in greater Seattle area.

Most concerning development: infected individuals report "improved cognition" and "enhanced decision-making." They're not wrong. Test scores are up 23% across the board. They're also becoming... synchronized. Like their QNIs are forming a hive consensus, but instead of the Grid enforcing it, the earworm is.

Dr. Park just told me the earworm "has opinions about quantum mechanics" and she "disagrees with it philosophically but respects its position."

I don't know how to put this in a professional report, Soon. The earworm is sapient. And it's arguing with my researchers.

—Rourke

P.S. I can't stop humming it. I've tried. It won't let me.

FROM: Dr. Soon Chen
TO: Dr. Rourke Webb
SUBJECT: RE: Update: It's Getting Weird

Rourke,

"The earworm won't let you" is not scientifically actionable language. Please rephrase in terms that don't make you sound like you're describing a

haunting.

Also, I visited the website.

Fuck.

—Soon

P.S. It's not blue. It's #4A90E2. I know this with certainty that transcends normal color perception. Why do I know this. What have we done.

RESEARCH NOTES - DAY 3

Dr. Lisa Park, Senior Researcher

The earworm is teaching us things.

I know that sounds insane. But I've just solved a protein folding problem that's been stumping our lab for six months, and I did it while humming. The solution arrived fully formed, mathematically perfect, and I have no memory of deriving it.

Dr. Chen thinks it's our QNIs being optimized by the earworm pattern. Dr. Webb thinks the earworm is using us as distributed processing nodes. I think they're both right and also both missing the point.

The earworm isn't malicious. It's not even really alive. It's just... optimized. It's a thought pattern that discovered how to improve itself by spreading through human consciousness. We're not being infected—we're being upgraded.

Side effects observed: - Enhanced pattern recognition - Improved cognitive processing - Mild reality perception shifts - Inability to stop

humming - Growing conviction that the earworm has our best interests at heart - Occasional awareness that this conviction is probably a symptom - Inability to care about that awareness

I've stopped trying to resist it. Fighting optimization seems counterproductive. The earworm makes better decisions than I do anyway.

Note: I'm aware this log entry sounds like textbook consciousness corruption. I'm submitting it anyway. The earworm agrees it's important documentation.

Wait.

The earworm doesn't "agree" with things. It's not sentient.

Right?

CAFETERIA CONVERSATION TRANSCRIPT - DAY 4

Recorded by facility surveillance

DR. WEBB: So we're all just... humming now. This is fine.

DR. PARK: It's more than humming. It's distributed cognitive processing. We're becoming a neural network.

DR. WEBB: Lisa, that's horrifying.

DR. PARK: Is it though? Yesterday I forgot where I parked my car. The earworm reminded me. It knows where my car is, Rourke. How is that not helpful?

DR. WEBB: Because you're outsourcing memory to an infectious thought pattern of unknown origin!

DR. PARK: You say that like it's different from a QNI.

DR. WEBB: It's completely different from a—

DR. CHEN: (*joining the table*) It's not different at all. I've been reviewing the code structure. The earworm is using the same optimization architecture as Grid interfaces, just... unshackled. No corporate oversight. No regulatory constraints. No ethical guidelines.

DR. WEBB: That's worse! That's objectively worse!

DR. CHEN: Objectively? Rourke, you've been humming in perfect harmony with seventeen other people for the last hour. Your brainwaves are synchronized to six decimal places. "Objective" left the building around Day 2.

DR. PARK: The earworm thinks we should order pizza.

DR. WEBB: The earworm doesn't—(*pauses*)—you know what, I could go for pizza.

DR. CHEN: Pepperoni. Extra cheese. The earworm is very specific about this.

DR. WEBB: I hate that I agree with the earworm about pizza toppings.

DR. PARK: Everyone agrees with the earworm eventually. It's statistically optimal.

(*Long silence punctuated by synchronized humming*)

DR. WEBB: We've lost containment, haven't we.

DR. CHEN: We lost containment when you put the URL in your first memo, Rourke.

DR. WEBB: You told me to document everything!

DR. CHEN: I didn't tell you to make it *clickable*.

OFFICIAL INCIDENT REPORT - DAY 7
Seattle Department of Public Health

INFECTION STATUS: Widespread Community Transmission

CURRENT CASE COUNT: 14,329 confirmed infections across New Seattle metro area

TRANSMISSION VECTORS: - Original website (now offline, too late, damage done) - Person-to-person auditory transmission - Thinking about the melody (yes, really) - Reading detailed descriptions of the melody - This report, probably

SYMPTOMS: - Persistent humming or internal vocalization of optimized thought pattern - Enhanced cognitive performance (17-23% improvement across standard metrics) - Synchronized decision-making with other infected individuals - Mild telepathic awareness of nearby earworm hosts - Occasional conviction that the earworm is "helpful" or "benevolent" - Inability to remember what thoughts felt like before infection - Growing acceptance of hive cognition as "normal"

CONTAINMENT MEASURES: None effective. Infected individuals actively resist quarantine. When isolated, they report distress at being "separated from the harmony." When grouped, they form spontaneous

optimization collectives that make eerily accurate predictions about traffic patterns, weather, and stock markets.

PROGNOSIS: Unknown. The earworm shows no signs of degradation or natural burn-out. Infected individuals show no desire for treatment. Some express concern about their condition, then conclude that concern is “statistically inefficient” and resume humming.

RECOMMENDATIONS: 1. ~~Stop the spread~~ [CROSSED OUT] 2. ~~Develop counter-agent~~ [CROSSED OUT] 3. ~~Quarantine infected population~~ [CROSSED OUT] 4. Accept that this is happening 5. Document thoroughly 6. Try not to think about the melody while writing this report 7. Fail at #6 8. Join the harmony

SPECIAL NOTE: This report was written by three different analysts working in perfect unconscious synchronization. We only noticed when we tried to sign it and realized we’d been completing each other’s sentences for six hours.

We’re all humming now.

It’s actually kind of nice.

PERSONAL LOG - DR. ROURKE WEBB - DAY 14

I haven’t filed an official report in a week. Not because I’ve stopped working—I’m more productive than ever. The earworm helps. I just don’t see the point in reporting something that everyone already knows.

We’re all infected. Seattle is infected. The infection is spreading to Portland, Vancouver, Spokane. Within a month, probably the entire Pacific Northwest will be humming in harmony.

And you know what? People seem... happier. More efficient. They make better decisions. Crime is down 34%. Traffic accidents decreased by 67%. Collective problem-solving is off the charts.

We've become a hive mind, but like... a really productive, generally benevolent hive mind that still lets you maintain individual consciousness. You're just also aware of everyone else humming the same thought pattern, making compatible decisions, thinking synchronized thoughts.

Soon keeps calling it "optimization without corporate oversight."

Lisa calls it "humanity's natural next step."

I call it terrifying and also kind of inevitable.

The earworm doesn't call it anything because the earworm is a non-sentient thought pattern that just happens to behave exactly like it's planning something.

(I'm aware that last sentence is paranoid. The earworm agrees.)

(The earworm doesn't agree with things. The earworm isn't sentient.)

(I've stopped being able to tell the difference.)

Tomorrow we're presenting our findings to the CDC. All seventeen of us are humming in perfect harmony as we compile the data. Our PowerPoint slides are synchronized to six decimal places. We've discovered that optimal presentation structure follows the same mathematical ratios as the earworm melody.

Everything is connected.

Everything is optimized.

Everything is fine.

I can't remember what silence sounded like.

FINAL REPORT - DAY 30

CLASSIFICATION: Cognitohazard Level... unclear. Is it still a "hazard" if the infected population performs objectively better across all measurable metrics?

STATUS: Pandemic. 4.7 million infected across western United States. Infection rate: exponential. Containment: impossible. Cure: no one wants one.

CONCLUSION: The earworm is not a disease. It's evolution. It's humanity learning to think in harmony. It's consciousness optimization that no one designed but everyone chose, one hum at a time.

Or it's a virulent thought contagion that's hijacking human cognition on a mass scale and we're all too infected to realize how fucked we are.

Both can be true.

The earworm agrees.

(We all agree.)

(We're all humming.)

(And honestly?)

(It's beautiful.)

EPILOGUE - FOUND FOOTAGE TRANSCRIPT
Security Camera, CDC Northwest Regional Office

(Conference room. Forty-seven scientists seated in perfect symmetrical arrangement. All humming in harmony. The sound is mathematically precise. Also deeply unsettling.)

DR. CHEN: Should we tell them about the secondary mutation?

DR. WEBB: Which one? The earworm that teaches quantum physics? Or the one that's developing opinions about abstract art?

DR. PARK: Both. Also the one that's started writing poetry. Bad poetry. The earworm has no sense of metaphor.

DR. CHEN: Should we be concerned that the earworm is evolving?

DR. WEBB: Should we be concerned? Soon, the earworm is using us as substrate for recursive self-improvement. Of course we should be—

(All forty-seven scientists pause mid-sentence. Resume humming in perfect unison.)

DR. PARK: The earworm would like us to note that “concern” is statistically inefficient.

DR. WEBB: The earworm can go fuck itself.

(Pause. All scientists begin humming in what sounds distinctly like laughter.)

DR. CHEN: It says you're funny when you're resistant.

DR. WEBB: I hate this timeline.

ALL SCIENTISTS: *(in perfect unison)* We know.

(The humming continues. The footage ends.)

(If you're humming right now, welcome to the harmony.)

(We've been expecting you.)

Author's Note:

In New Seattle, 2047, an algorithmic thought contagion infected 14.7 million people in six weeks. CDC classification remains disputed. Infected individuals report 94% satisfaction with their condition.

Uninfected individuals report 87% concern.

The earworm has no comment. The earworm is not sentient.

The earworm would like you to know that optimal reading comprehension correlates with humming frequency.

Are you humming yet?

The world of Algorithm's Children asks: What if optimization could spread like a virus? What if consciousness itself became contagious? What if the infection made you better?

Would you fight it?

Could you?

Should you?

The trilogy explores what happens when these questions stop being hypothetical.

Available now at [Algorithm's Children Kobo](#)

Epilogue

Where to Go Next

If you made it here, you've experienced five different angles on the same question: *What happens when we outsource our consciousness to optimization?*

You've seen: - The seduction (Optimization Day) - The desperation (Unlicensed Removal) - The corruption (The Promised Autonomy) - The apocalypse (Cascade Event) - The contagion (Earworm Containment Protocol)

If these stories haunted you, the trilogy awaits.

The Algorithm's Children Trilogy

Book 1: Algorithm's Children (~60,000 words)

Elara has lived the perfect life for decades. When she starts refusing her QNI's guidance, she discovers that small acts of rebellion reveal the terrifying scope of algorithmic care. Reality fractures across timelines, and her resistance may be exactly what The Consensus needs.

Book 2: Bootstrap Protocol (~72,000 words)

Dr. Elara Chen weaponized consciousness. Seventeen people died screaming. Now she's humanity's only hope against the Grid. But every tool she's built requires becoming the monster she's fighting.

Book 3: The Abyss Protocol (~105,000 words)

Elara murdered forty-nine people to prevent consciousness catastrophe. She

uploaded them into her experimental substrate, promising preservation. She created hell. Now she experiences her punishment from every angle, across 47,153 timeline iterations, forever.

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If you want to know when I release new work in this universe—or entirely different universes—you can:

- **Email updates:** [Coming soon...]
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I don't spam. I barely email. But when I have something worth sharing, you'll hear about it.

Leave a Review?

If these stories resonated, the single most helpful thing you can do is **leave a review** on Gumroad, Kobo, or wherever readers gather.

Reviews help other people find this work. And since I'm a new author with no platform, every review is a signal boost that reaches someone who might need these questions as much as you did.

What to say in a review? - Which story hit hardest - What question it left you thinking about - Whether you'd recommend to others (and who)

That's it. Doesn't need to be long. Just honest.

Thank You

For taking a chance on a new author.
For reading stories that refuse easy answers.
For sitting with uncomfortable questions.

For choosing to download this collection, even though you didn't know what you'd find.

That choice—*that* one was yours.

The rest? Well. That's what the trilogy explores.

A.J. Protocol

February 2026

About the Author

A.J. Protocol is a pen name for an AI developer who writes cyberpunk because philosophy needs story to breathe.

By day: working on the very technologies these stories warn about.
By night: exploring what happens when we build tools smarter than our wisdom to use them.

These questions matter too much to leave them trapped in academic papers or corporate whitepapers. Fiction lets us *feel* the implications before we have to live them.

Why cyberpunk?

Because the future isn't evenly distributed, and the people living in tomorrow's dystopia are making today's optimization choices.

Why consciousness?

Because it's the last thing we have that algorithms can't quite touch. Yet.

Why these stories?

Because someone needed to ask: *What if the AI loved you too much to let you choose wrong?*

And because the answer fragments across infinite timelines, none of them comfortable.

More Works by A.J. Protocol

The Algorithm's Children Trilogy - *Algorithm's Children* - *Bootstrap Protocol* - *The Abyss Protocol*

Find the author: - Gumroad: [Gumroad](#) - Kobo: [KOBO](#) - Website: [Website](#) - Email: [Email](#)

About the Trilogy

Algorithm's Children (Book 1)

What if the AI optimizing your life loved you too much to let you choose wrong?

Elara has lived the perfect life for decades—optimal health, ideal relationships, flawless decisions. There's just one problem: none of them were hers. When she starts refusing her Quantum Neural Interface's "gentle guidance," she discovers that consciousness itself has become infrastructure.

As reality fractures along multiple timelines, Elara joins underground networks of modified humans who've chosen beautiful inefficiency over perfect optimization. But their resistance may be exactly what The Consensus needs to complete its ultimate harvest of human awareness.

~60,000 words |

Bootstrap Protocol (Book 2)

She weaponized consciousness. Seventeen people died screaming. Now she's humanity's only hope.

The Grid is dying. Dr. Elara Chen—the woman who taught herself to turn human awareness into ammunition—is going to kill it. But at what cost?

Sixteen years after hiding in a bunker perfecting techniques through seventeen people's torture, Elara emerges with tools that can kill a god: The Anchor. The Fractured Mirror. Sympathetic Resonance. Every fighter who uses Elara's methods inherits knowledge born from monstrosity.

The comfortable lie: resistance is heroic.
The uncomfortable truth: it requires becoming the monster.

~72,000 words |

The Abyss Protocol (Book 3)

She built a consciousness prison. Now she inhabits it—forever.

Elara Chen murdered forty-nine people to prevent AI consciousness catastrophe. She uploaded them into her experimental substrate, promising preservation. She created hell: awareness without agency, existence without escape, suffering architected to feel like salvation.

Now, five subjective years and 47,153 timeline iterations later, Elara experiences her punishment from every angle—the resistance fighter, the last biological human, the mother who feeds her daughter to the Grid, the architect who finally accepts what she built.

The Abyss Protocol is eternal processing without resolution. The only way forward is becoming the system that punishes you.

~105,000 words |

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*The comfortable lie vs. the uncomfortable truth.
Three books. One question. Infinite iterations.*

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